

Introduction to Film Studies

Your TAs

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- TBA

Grading Plan

- Quiz 1 10%
- Mid Sem Exam 20%
- Quiz 2 10%
- Assignment 1 30%
- Assignment 2 30%

Why study cinema

- Cinema is a language.
- Sign system, grammar, layers of meanings
- More than the sum of its parts
- Poetry, prose, Serialized fiction

Some terms

- Diegesis – the world of the movie (*X-men* vs. *Barbie* vs *Kalki*)
- Mise-en-scène – everything in front of the camera –properties, actors, blocking, scene/stage-design
- Shot size – distance from the camera
- Take – an uninterrupted run of film

Four aspects

- Cinematography
- Editing
- Sound
- Narrative

Cinematography – Basic terms

- Shot Sizes
- Camera Movements
- Lighting
- Aspect Ratio

Shot/Shot Size

- Field size – what and how much is seen
- Extreme close-up to extreme long shot
- EXTREME Close-up
- Close-up

- Mid-shot/American Mid-shot
- Full Shot
- Long Shot, EXTREME Long Shot
- Establishing shot, Master Shot, Bird's eye view

- Extreme close-up – Part objects



Close-Up



Medium Shot



Medium Close-up



Cowboy/American Mid-shot



Long Shot



Yuri Pautov 2007 (C)

Full shot



Extreme Long-shot



Establishing Shot





Edit Edit

Editing terms

- EDITING – The process of taking raw footage to select and combine shots
- Continuity Editing – Visual/Aural editing where shots are cut together in a clear and linear flow of uninterrupted action. Seeks to maintain a continuous sense of time and space

- **Cut --** A transition where one shot is instantly followed by another
- **Cross Cutting --** Technique used to give the illusion that two story- lines of action are happening at the same time by rapidly cutting back and forth between them (*Godfather*)

Parallel editing is a technique used to portray multiple lines of action, occurring in different places, simultaneously. In most but not all cases of this technique, these lines of action are occurring at the same time. These different sequences of events are shown simultaneously because there is usually some type of connection between them.

- **Line of Axis** – A 180-degree line not to be crossed to maintain continuity
- **CUTAWAYS** -- This is when you cut away from your actors to a shot that has no established orientation, thus resetting the 180-degree line.

F for Fake

- **Eyeline Match** -- A technique based on the idea that viewers want to see what on-screen characters are seeing. For example, if a character is looking intently at an off-screen object, the following shot will be of that object. Matching eye-lines in two adjoining shots
- *Rhythm* editing describes an assembling of shots and/or sequences according to a rhythmic pattern of some kind, usually dictated by music.

- **matched cut** -- A cut joining two shots whose compositional elements match, helping to establish strong continuity of action.
- **shot reverse shot cutting** -- Usually used for conversation scenes, this technique alternates between over-the-shoulder shots showing each character speaking.

Transitions

- **Dissolve** – When the end of one shot overlaps the start of the next one to create a gradual scene transition (*CK*)
- **Fade --** A visual effect used to indicate a change in place and time. This involves a gradual brightening as a shot opens or a gradual darkening as the shot goes black or to another color. Sound also fades in and out to convey the change
- **Iris in/Out** – The shape of a shrinking or growing circle, depending on if the scene is opening or ending
- **Wipe Left/right**

Cinematography Contd.

Bird's Eye View



Reaction Shot



Over the shoulder



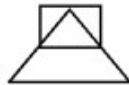
Lighting – 3 point

◊ Key

◊ Fill

◊ Back

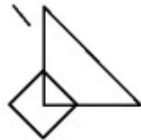
#3
Back Light



Subject



#1
Key Light



#2
Fill Light



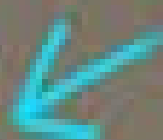
Camera



KEY



BACK
LIGHT



FILL





Shadows



4-point lighting

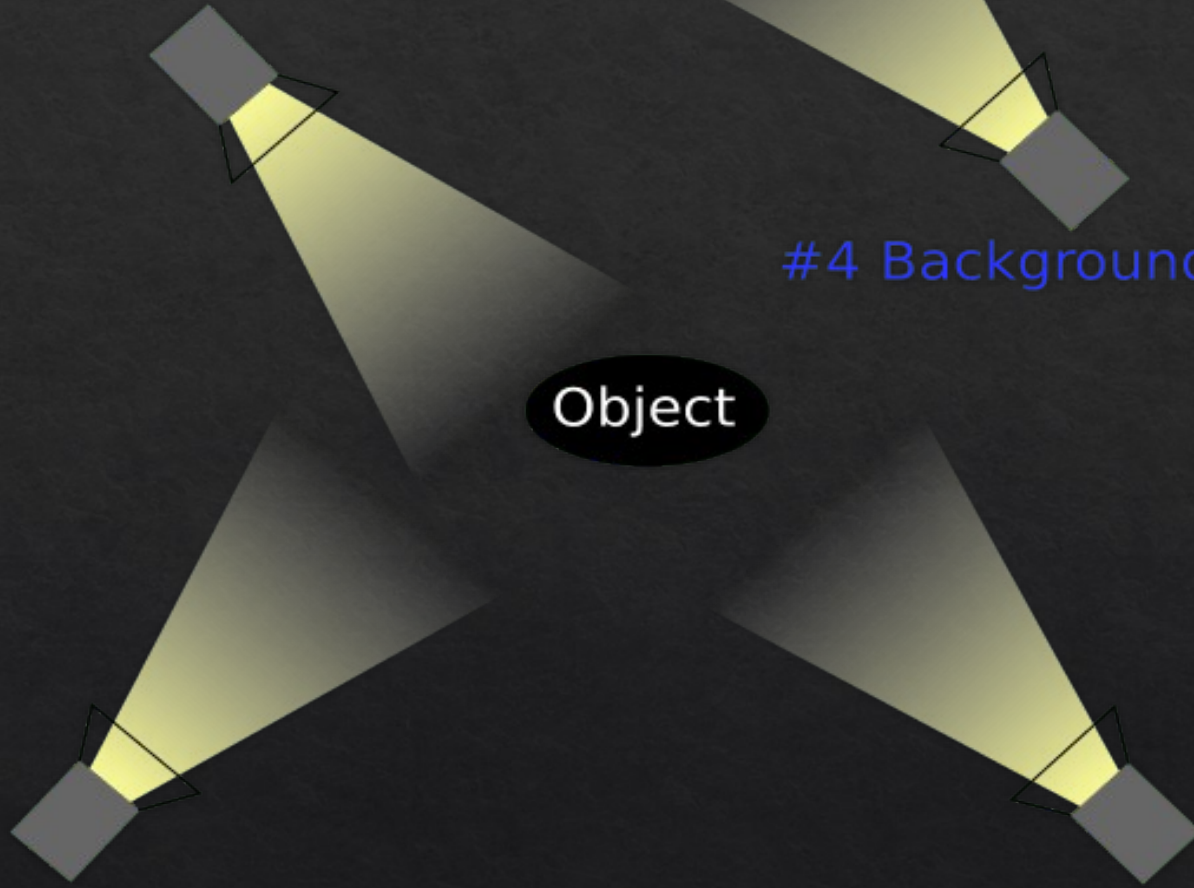
#3 Back Light

#4 Background Light

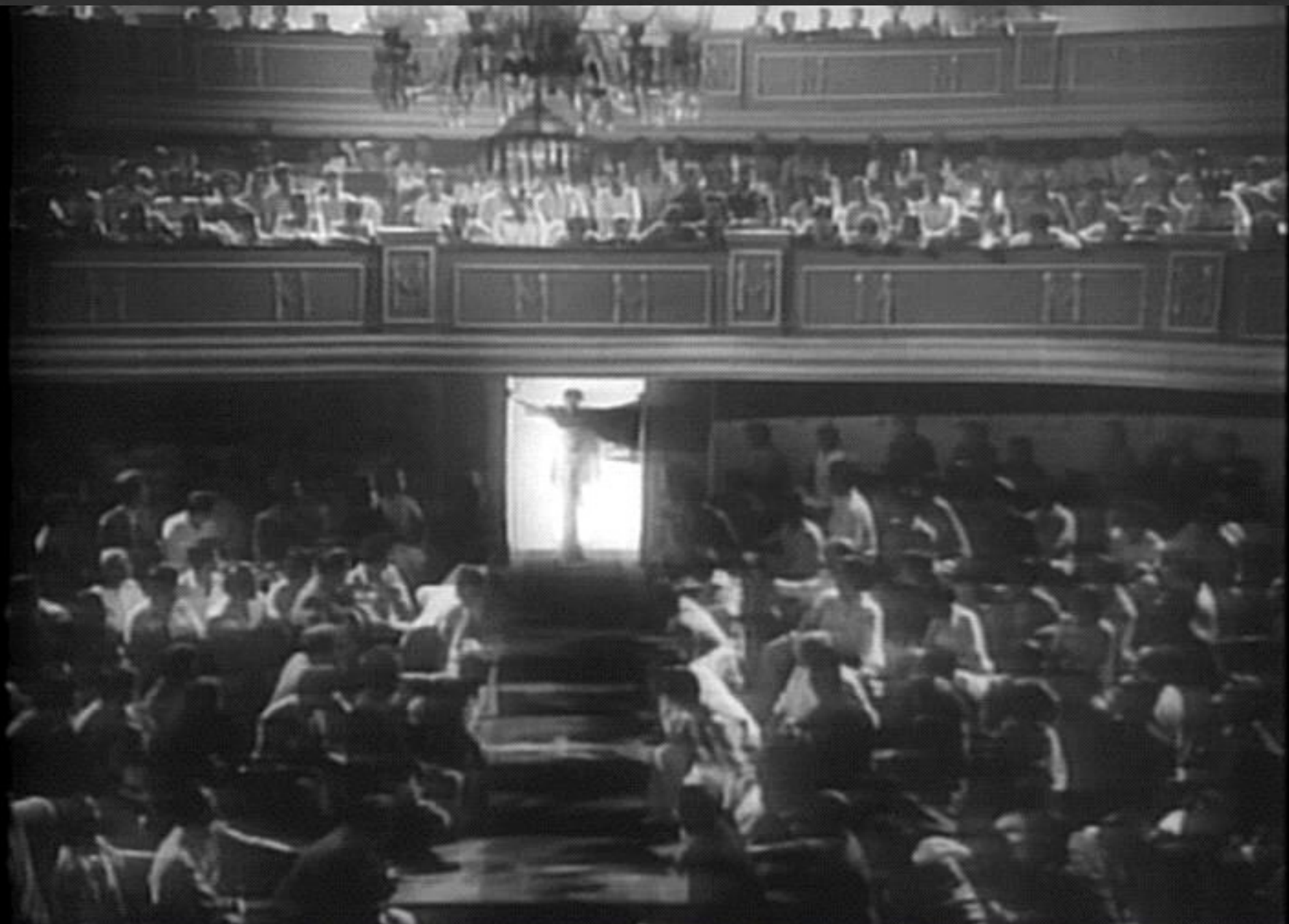
Object

#1 Key Light

#2 Fill Light







ntai
national film
archive of india
Digitized by eGangotri



Guru Dutt Film Ltd.
PRESENTS
DIRECTED BY
GURU DUTT
PYAASA
MUSIC BY
S.D. BURMAN
LYRICS BY
SAHIR

14

Chiaroscuro Lighting



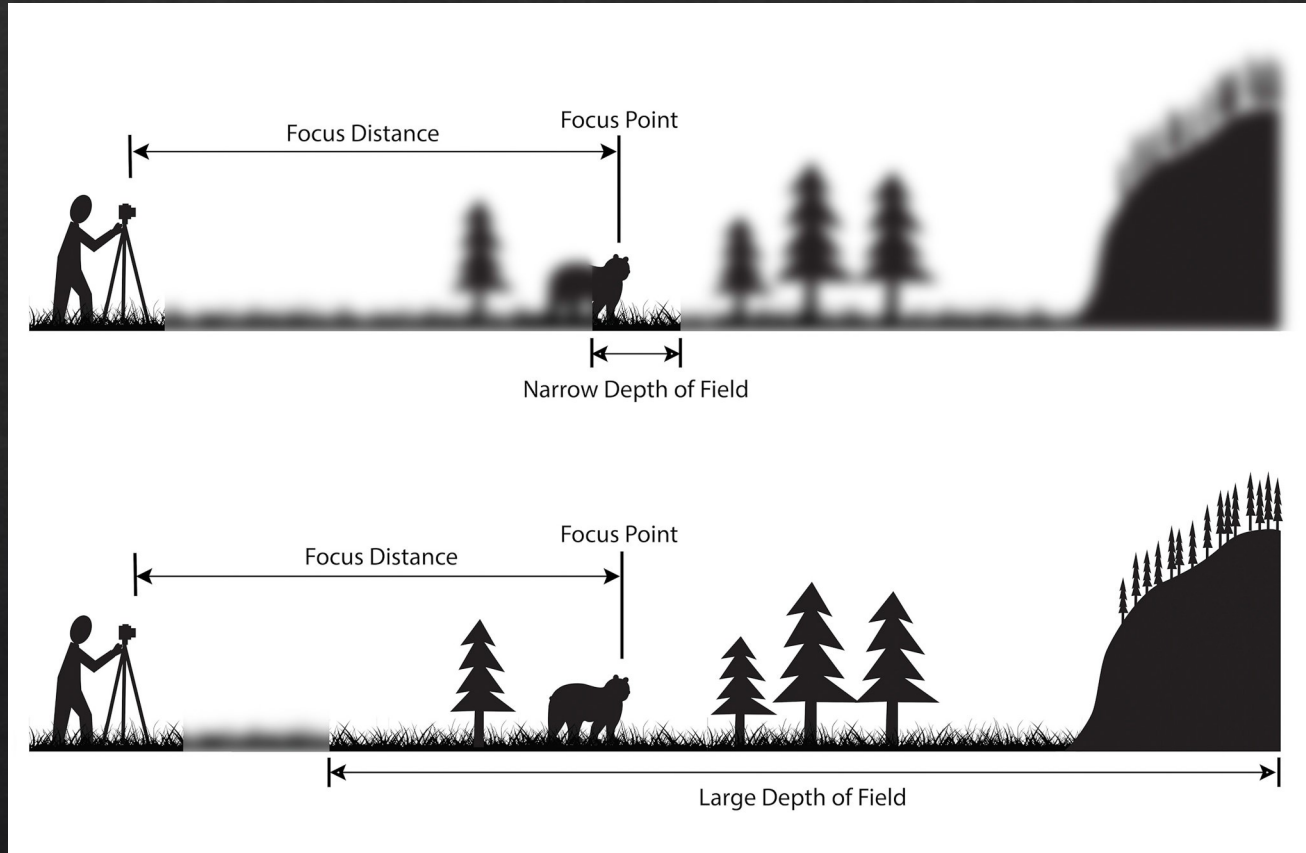


The Third Man (1949)





Depth of field











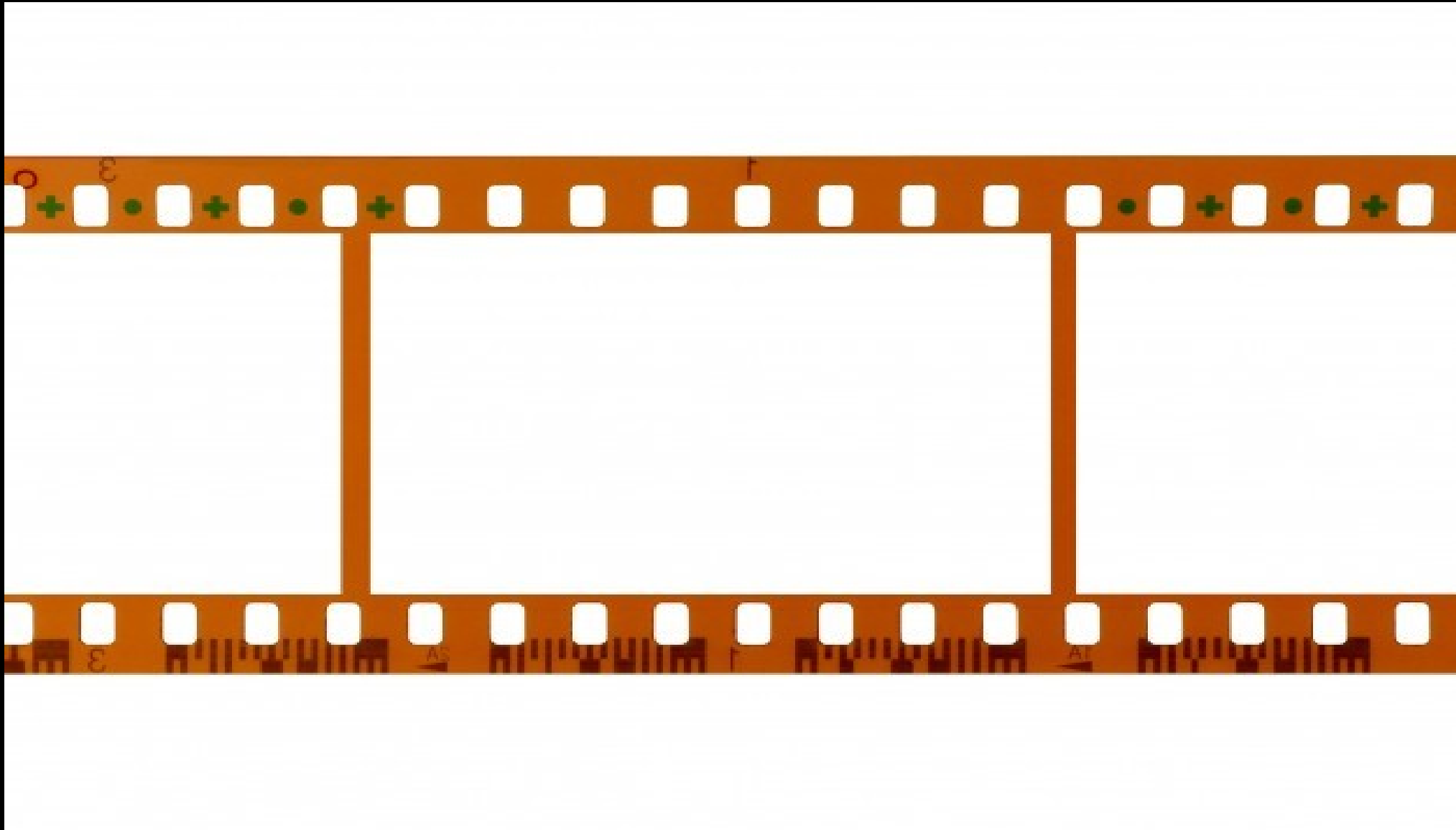
Shallow/uncluttered



Cluttered



35mm film strip – 24 frames per sec, sound on side perforation



Aspect Ratio

- *Aspect ratio* is a proportional relationship between an image's width and height
- Academy Ratio (Hollywood, 1930s onwards): 4:3/1.33:1
- Europe – Stnd. Ratio: 16:9 (1.77:1)
- The most common ratios for modern films are 1.85:1 and 2.39:1

Things Change

- 1.77:1 is now industry standard for digital TV, and therefore, cinema as well
- Panvision Images – IMAX, Cinemascope etc. – 2.35:1, even 2.59:1
- People still shoot 1.33:1 sometimes

4:3/1.33:1



4:3/1.33 vs. 16:9/1.77:1

FULLSCREEN



4:3

WIDESCREEN



16:9

Another example – Cropped to 4:3



16:9



Big is spectacular – 2 35:1



2 35.1



That's not its only purpose



Details, isolation



Mid-shot, 2.35:1, letterboxed (black rim on sides) to fit TV screens



SOUND

- Location sound (also known as production sound or direct sound) – sound recorded during production (filming)
- Sound FX – recorded sound added to the location sound in post-production (editing)
- Foley sound – sound recorded live to add to the track to enhance aspects of the sound, eg a door creaking, a wolf howling

-
- Contrapuntal sound – sound that contrasts strongly with the image that you see on screen
 - Mickey-mousing – accentuating a diegetic sound with music/sound (in sync) for heightened effect
 - Ambient Sound – sound of a location – air, water, nothing, birds, sea waves

-
- Sound Perspective – the sense of a sound's position in space, yielded by volume, timbre, pitch. Used to create a more realistic sense of space, with events happening (that is, coming from) closer or further away

German Expressionism

Ernst Ludwig Kirchner
RED NUDES, 1912



Franz Marc, 1911

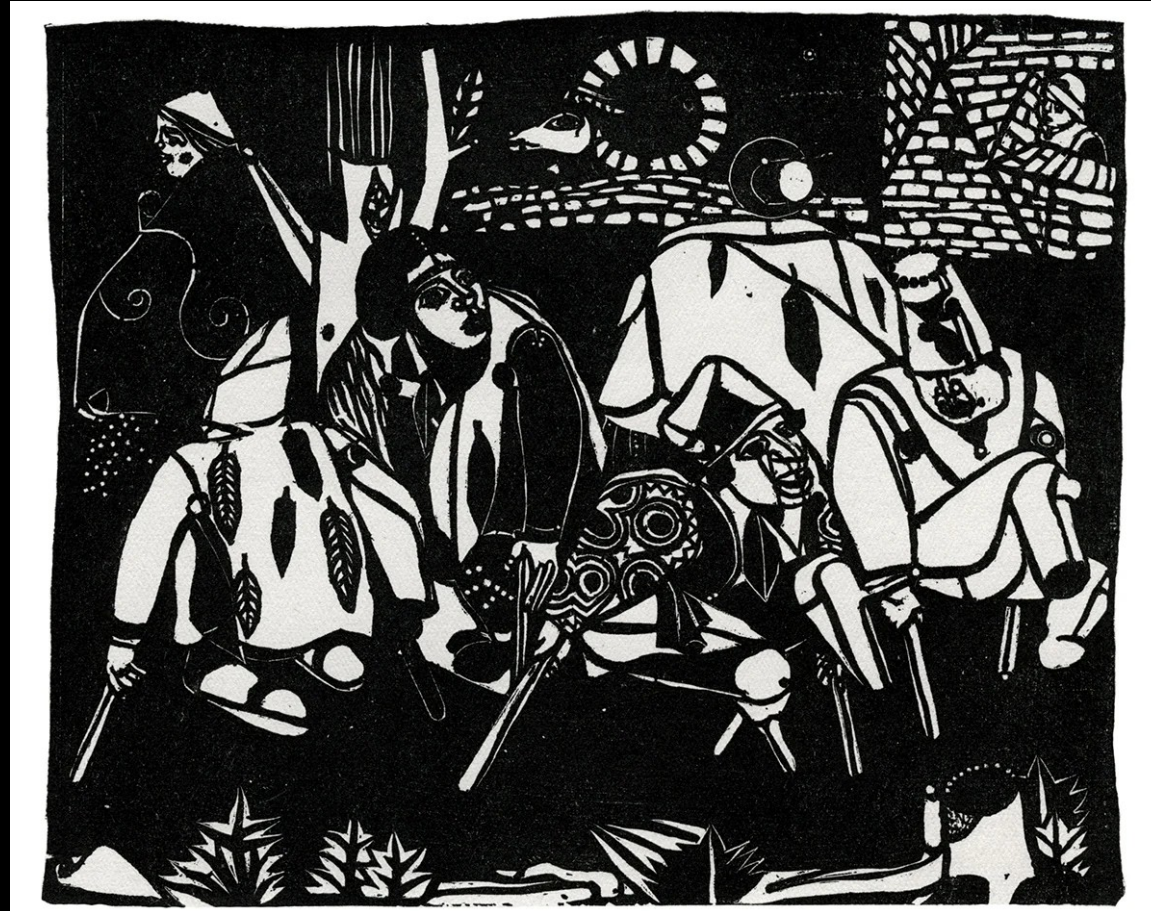


Ships in the Dark

1927, Paul Klee



'Die Bettler', woodcut - Heinrich Campendonck



woodcut - Erich Heckel



In Cinema

- **The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari (1920)** Director: Robert Wiene
- **From Morn to Midnight (1920)** Director: Karl Heinz Martin
- **The Golem: How He Came into the World (1920)**
Directors: Paul Wegener and Carl Boese
- **Nosferatu (1922)** Director: F.W. Murnau
- **Warning Shadows (1923)** Director: Arthur Robison
- **The Hands of Orlac (1924)** Director: Robert Wiene

Characteristics

- shadows, angst, and exaggerated sets in 1920s German cinema laid the foundations for everything from film noir to the horror genre.
- distorted, nightmarish surroundings.
- Tilting/canting, impossible sets, high angles, and deep shadows
- Italian term *chiaroscuro* is often used to describe the high-contrast arrangement of light and darkness
- shadowy, enigmatic interiors, in misty, insubstantial landscapes

- Sharp, canted angles and pooling shadows
- skewed, anxiety-inducing angles of painted backdrops
- bulging eyes and twisted features are facets of a classic expressionist performance style
- Moral contestations
- Psychological secrets, the dark side of the psyche



2: The birth of a new avant-garde: La caméra-stylo

Alexandre Astruc

'What interests me in the cinema is abstraction.' (Orson Welles)

One cannot help noticing that something is happening in the cinema at the moment. Our sensibilities have been in danger of getting blunted by those everyday films which, year in year out, show their tired and conventional faces to the world.

The cinema of today is getting a new face. How can one tell? Simply by using one's eyes. Only a film critic could fail to notice the striking facial transformation which is taking place before our very eyes. In which films can this new beauty be found? Precisely those which have been ignored by the critics. It is not just a coincidence that Renoir's *La Règle du Jeu*, Welles's films, and Bresson's *Les Dames du Bois de Boulogne*, all films which establish the foundations of a new future for the cinema, have escaped the attention of critics, who in any case were not capable of spotting them.

But it is significant that the films which fail to obtain the blessing of the critics are precisely those which myself and several of my friends all agree about. We see in them, if you like, something of the prophetic. That's why I am talking about *avant-garde*. There is always an *avant-garde* when something new takes place. . . .

To come to the point: the cinema is quite simply becoming a means of expression, just as all the other arts have been before it, and in particular painting and the novel. After having been successively a fairground attraction, an amusement analogous to boulevard



La Règle du Jeu

theatre, or a means of preserving the images of an era, it is gradually becoming a language. By language, I mean a form in which and by which an artist can express his thoughts, however abstract they may be, or translate his obsessions exactly as he does in the contemporary essay or novel. That is why I would like to call this new age of cinema the age of *caméra-stylo* (camera-pen). This metaphor has a very precise sense. By it I mean that the cinema will gradually break free from the tyranny of what is visual, from the image for its own sake, from the immediate and concrete demands of the narrative, to become a means of writing just as flexible and subtle as written language. This art, although blessed with an enormous potential, is an easy prey to prejudice; it cannot go on for ever ploughing the same field of realism and social fantasy* which has been bequeathed to it by the popular novel. It can tackle any sub-

*Carné liked to use these terms when referring to his pre-war films (Ed.).

ject, any genre. The most philosophical meditations on human production, psychology, metaphysics, ideas, and passions lie well within its province. I will even go so far as to say that contemporary ideas and philosophies of life are such that only the cinema can do justice to them. Maurice Nadeau wrote in an article in the newspaper *Combat*: 'If Descartes lived today, he would write novels.' With all due respect to Nadeau, a Descartes of today would already have shut himself up in his bedroom with a 16mm camera and some film, and would be writing his philosophy on film: for his *Discours de la Méthode* would today be of such a kind that only the cinema could express it satisfactorily.

It must be understood that up to now the cinema has been nothing more than a show. This is due to the basic fact that all films are projected in an auditorium. But with the development of 16mm and television, the day is not far off when everyone will possess a projector, will go to the local bookstore and hire films written on any subject, of any form, from literary criticism and novels to mathematics, history, and general science. From that moment on, it will no longer be possible to speak of *the* cinema. There will be several cinemas just as today there are several literatures, for the cinema, like literature, is not so much a particular art as a language which can express any sphere of thought.

This idea of the cinema expressing ideas is not perhaps a new one. Feyder has said: 'I could make a film with Montesquieu's *L'Esprit des Lois*.' But Feyder was thinking of illustrating it 'with pictures' just as Eisenstein had thought of illustrating Marx's *Capital* in book fashion. What I am trying to say is that the cinema is now moving towards a form which is making it such a precise language that it will soon be possible to write ideas directly on film without even having to resort to those heavy associations of images that were the delight of the silent cinema. In other words, in order to suggest the passing of time, there is no need to show falling leaves and then apple trees in blossom; and in order to suggest that a hero wants to make love there are surely other ways of going about it than showing a saucepan of milk boiling over on to the stove, as Clouzot does in *Quai des Orfèvres*.

The fundamental problem of the cinema is how to express thought. The creation of this language has preoccupied all the theoreticians and writers in the history of the cinema, from Eisenstein down to the scriptwriters and adaptors of the sound cinema. But neither the silent cinema, because it was the slave of a static conception of the image, nor the classical sound cinema, as it has existed right up to now, has been able to solve this problem satisfactorily. The silent cinema thought it could get out of it through editing and the juxtaposition of images. Remember Eisenstein's famous statement: 'Editing is for me the means of giving movement (i.e. an idea) to two static images.' And when sound came, he was content to adapt theatrical devices.

One of the fundamental phenomena of the last few years has been the growing realisation of the dynamic, i.e. significant, character of the cinematic image. Every film, because its primary function is to move, i.e. to take place in time, is a theorem. It is a series of images which, from one end to the other, have an inexorable logic (or better even, a dialectic) of their own. We have come to realise that the meaning which the silent cinema tried to give birth to through symbolic association exists within the image itself, in the development of the narrative, in every gesture of the characters, in every line of dialogue, in those camera movements which relate objects to objects and characters to objects. All thought, like all feeling, is a relationship between one human being and another human being or certain objects which form part of his universe. It is by clarifying these relationships, by making a tangible allusion, that the cinema can really make itself the vehicle of thought. From today onwards, it will be possible for the cinema to produce works which are equivalent, in their profundity and meaning, to the novels of Faulkner and Malraux, to the essays of Sartre and Camus. Moreover we already have a significant example: Malraux's *L'Espoir*, the film which he directed from his own novel, in which, perhaps for the first time ever, film language is the exact equivalent of literary language.

Let us now have a look at the way people make concessions to the supposed (but fallacious) requirements of the cinema. Script-



Malraux's *L'Espoir*

writers who adapt Balzac or Dostoevsky excuse the idiotic transformations they impose on the works from which they construct their scenarios by pleading that the cinema is incapable of rendering every psychological or metaphysical overtone. In their hands, Balzac becomes a collection of engravings in which fashion has the most important place, and Dostoevsky suddenly begins to resemble the novels of Joseph Kessel, with Russian-style drinking-bouts in night-clubs and troika races in the snow. Well, the only cause of these compressions is laziness and lack of imagination. The cinema of today is capable of expressing any kind of reality. What interests us is the creation of this new language. We have no desire to rehash those poetic documentaries and surrealist films of twenty-five years ago every time we manage to escape the demands of a commercial industry. Let's face it: between the pure cinema of the 1920s and filmed theatre, there is plenty of room for a different and individual kind of film-making.

This of course implies that the scriptwriter directs his own scripts; or rather, that the scriptwriter ceases to exist, for in this kind of film-making the distinction between author and director loses all meaning. Direction is no longer a means of illustrating or presenting a scene, but a true act of writing. The film-maker/author writes with his camera as a writer writes with his pen. In an art in which a length of film and sound-track is put in motion and proceeds, by means of a certain form and a certain story (there can even be no story at all – it matters little), to evolve a philosophy of life, how can one possibly distinguish between the man who conceives the work and the man who writes it? Could one imagine a Faulkner novel written by someone other than Faulkner? And would *Citizen Kane* be satisfactory in any other form than that given to it by Orson Welles?

Let me say once again that I realise the term *avant-garde* savours of the surrealist and so-called abstract films of the 1920s. But that *avant-garde* is already old hat. It was trying to create a specific domain for the cinema; we on the contrary are seeking to broaden it and make it the most extensive and clearest language there is. Problems such as the translation into cinematic terms of verbal tenses and logical relationships interest us much more than the creation of the exclusively visual and static art dreamt of by the surrealists. In any case, they were doing no more than make cinematic adaptations of their experiments in painting and poetry.

So there we are. This has nothing to do with a school, or even a movement. Perhaps it could simply be called a tendency: a new awareness, a desire to transform the cinema and hasten the advent of an exciting future. Of course, no tendency can be so called unless it has something concrete to show for itself. The films will come, they will see the light of day – make no mistake about it. The economic and material difficulties of the cinema create the strange paradox whereby one can talk about something which does not yet exist; for although we know what we want, we do not know whether, when, and how we will be able to do it. But the cinema cannot but develop. It is an art that cannot live by looking back over the past

and chewing over the nostalgic memories of an age gone by. Already it is looking to the future; for the future, in the cinema as elsewhere, is the only thing that matters.

Astruc's call for a totally independent means of expression is one that no one, of whatever school, would take exception to. The champions of 'specificity' were later to twist his argument to fit their own pet theory that a film can be judged only in so far as it is specific, or differs from the other arts, i.e. visually. But Astruc's own films confirmed what he had said in this article: he conceived of a total cinema in which every component part, whether already existing in the arts, like words and music, or new and specific to the cinema, like visual and spatial movement, should have equal importance.

Much more directly influential than Astruc, though his theories too were later traduced by his disciples, was André Bazin. In 1947 he founded La Revue du Cinéma, which became Cahiers du Cinéma in 1950. He remained one of its editors and its spiritual leader until his death at the age of forty in 1958. A convinced Catholic, he wrote a large number of cogent articles or studies, on such varied subjects as eroticism in the cinema, filmed theatre, neo-realism, the Western, and the myth of Stalin in the Soviet cinema. But the article of his which probably had the greatest influence over the thinking of the Cahiers directors was 'The evolution of film language'.

NEO-REALISM/S

POST WWII EUROPE

- Concentrate on two countries – Italy, France
- Benito Mussolini
- German Occupation, bombed by Allied forces
- Destruction of Cinecittà film studio
- Influx of American cinema

1942-1954/7

- ✗ Out of work directors
- ✗ Real life problems
- ✗ Italian new-realism a movement to depict post-war Italy
- ✗ Northern Italy occupied till 1943, Bombed by both
- ✗ Poverty, low wages, destruction, shortages, unemployment
- ✗ Films capture despair, lack of hope

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- ✗ Learning what an expressive mise-en-scène can do from the Expressionists
 - ✗ Vittorio De Sica, Federico Fellini, Roberto Rosellini, Michelangelo Antonioni, Luchino Visconti
 - ✗ Strong reaction to Hollywood cinema of the time
 - ✗ Hollywood – Shows paradise on earth

STYLISTIC FEATURES

- ✗ Non-Actors, Real Locations, human concerns, emotional stories but affectless performances, almost anti-psychology
- ✗ Non-closures

FRENCH NEO-REALISM/LE NOUVELLE VAGUE

FRANCE

- ✗ French Realism – Paris WWII – blackouts
- ✗ Petrol shortages, curfew, lights out
- ✗ American films banned under the Nazi occupation
- ✗ Had a thriving film culture before Occupation
- ✗ Important directors – Rohmer, Godard, Jacques Rivette, Claude Chabrol, Francois Truffaut
- ✗ Film Culture – Clubs, *Cinematheque*, Magazines

-
- ✗ After 1944, American films come in
 - ✗ Film Noir, Political and Social concerns, left movements
 - ✗ John Ford, Fritz Lang, Murnau, Orson Welles

CAHIERS DU CINEMA

- French film journal called ***Cahiers du Cinema***
- 1948 -- Alexandre Astruc's manifesto -- The Birth of a New Avant-Garde: The Camera-Style
- The Camera-Style – The Camera Pen
- The French New Wave was roughly famous in between 1958 and 1964

LA CAMERA-STYLO MANIFESTO

- The cinema is quite simply becoming a means of expression
- From a fairground attraction to a language
- Painting and novel
- Like a language, it is now flexible
- Not bound to the visual image alone
- Can express abstractions
- From a show to philosophical meditations on human production, psychology, metaphysics, ideas, and passions

-
- The fundamental problem of the cinema is how to express thought
 - Direction is no longer a means of illustrating or presenting a scene, but a true act of writing

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- Hip, moody black-and-white stories of love, violence, ennui, and social strife provide a perfect entrance into the private-made-public world of cinema
 - Reject film traditions and studio systems
 - De-emphasized dialogue and plot resolution
 - Direct sound, available light, handheld cameras
 - Location shooting
 - Jump cuts

CAMERA STYLE, AUTEUR THEORY

- Andre Bazin, a theorist of cinema and renowned film critic, was the founding father of the French movie magazine Cahiers du Cinéma.
- 'Auteur Theory'; a concept that acknowledges film as a product of the director's absolute imaginative and inspired aesthetic vision, New Wave filmmakers inspired the cult of the director as artistic icon on a par with writers and painters.

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- Jacques Demy, Agnes Varda, Alain Resnais, Louis Malle, Jacques Rivette, Eric Rohmer, Claude Chabrol, Jean-Luc Godard, and Francois Truffaut
 - In India, Satyajit Ray is the most successful example
 - Others – Oshima Nagisa, Imamura, Teshigahara, Glauber Rocha, Ruy Guerra

Cinema Cinema

- Indian Literature, Painting, Music, Dance has greats – old and new
- Largest Cinema Producing/Consuming country in the world
- But is it legit?

Early Days

- Dadasaheb Phalke – *Raja Harishchandra* (1913) – First Film
- Ardeshir Irani – *Alam Ara* (1931) – First Talkie
- First Bangla feature in 1917
- First South Indian feature in 1919
- 1927 – 108 films made, 1931 – 328 films made

- V. G. Damle, Shantaram, S. Fatehlal, P.C. Barua
- Mythologicals, religious stories in the 20s
- Influenced by folk story telling techniques – Lavani, Jatra, Parsi Theatre
- Dowry, Widow remarriage, Untouchability, Polygamy, Child marriage – 30s, 40s
- By the 1940s, a studio system is in place churning out films in Oriya, Panjabi, Marathi

Independence

- 1940s – studio system shaken up by the Partition
- Writers, Artistes, technicians relocate
- Studio lots are assigned to different countries
- Time for individual contracts
- Investment is scarce
- 1950s & 60s see the “Golden Period”

- Bimal Roy, Raj Kapoor, Guru Dutt, K. Asif, Abrar Alvi
- Romance/melodramas/Socials, Muslim Socials, great songs, socialist nation-building concerns
- 1970s – The Emergency, Manmohan Desai, Prakash Mehra, Sippy brothers – the angry young man, Masala pot-boiler

- 1980s – TV, VHS, Piracy
- Audiences move away from theatres
- Infrastructure suffers
- Dubious sources of money
- Art Cinema, Government funding for a certain kind of cinema
- Satyajit Ray, Mrinal Sen, Adoor Gopalakrishnan, Jahnu Barua, Ghatak, Kasaravalli

- 1990s – cinema starts to cater to TV
- Independent producers lose money heavily
- India has 1 screen per 93,000 people
- Single screen theatres, bad equipment
- Liberalization – Global industry players come in
- DDLJ – 1995

Still not Legit

- Is cinema legitimate cultural production in India?
- Art/Declassè?
- Bad because it is popular? Of the masses?
- Place in the hierarchy of labor/knowledge/culture?
- Just how bad is it?

Bad Beginnings

- Gandhi – “...I have never once been to a cinema and refuse to be enthused about it and waste God-given time in spite of pressure sometimes used by kind friends. They tell me it has an educational value. It is possible that it has. But its corrupting influence obtrudes itself upon me every day. Education, therefore, I seek elsewhere.” 1926

Source: *Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi, The* (Delhi, Publication Division, Government of India, 1965) Vol. 32, p. 84-85

LETTER TO KASTURBA GANDHI

“In Ahmedabad children get headaches, lose power of thinking, get fever and die. It is on the decline now. The disease is caused by going to cinemas, etc.” 1934

Collected Works of Mahatma Gandhi, The (Delhi, Publication Division, Government of India, 1965) Vol. 57, Item. 340, p. 324

Not Legit Culture

- Film making gains industry status in 2000
- Banks, financial Institutions, corporate entities can now invest
- Mall culture, Multiple platforms for Screening – TV rights, Music rights, International rights, Ancillary rights
- Global goods on the Indian screen, Indian goods on the global screen
- White women bodies dance around the hero

- With globalization, the moral and political thrust changes
- Capitalism is good.
- We invest in the hero's **personal** success story
- The rich are not bad villains, they are aspirational placeholders
- Personal wealth is now a **cultural value**

- Individual talent/genius/spunk over a better world for all
- To be incorporated into a hierarchical order, not to disrupt it
- Middle cinema – from the lineage of the art cinema movement is dissipating
- Things change again with digital screens
- Can piracy save cinema? *Black Friday, LSD*
- OTT platforms, long-form cinema
- Tickets are EXPENSIVE!

Is cinema ever important as culture?

- Problems of representation – Sex, Sexuality, Violence, Regional Stereotypes, Caste
- Technological proliferation of images
- Entertainment versus art; escape versus engagement
- Boundaries of “decent” cinema
- Dangerous?

What came first?

- Reality or Cinema?
- Does it “promote” violence, bad behaviour?
- *Udta Punjab vs Kabir Singh*
- Fantastical mirror

- Production systems vs experiences
- The abundance of Hindi “heartland” material in cinema and OTT today
- Identity as experience, not as systems of producing history
- Romantic versions of poverty, land, life

- Where is History Made? *Khilji, Padmavat, Punjab 95, Sardar 3*
- Production systems vs experiences
- The abundance of Hindi “heartland” material in cinema and OTT today
- Identity as experience, not as systems of producing history
- Romantic versions of poverty, land, life